

15 “Used to” and “would”

When talking about habits or states in the past, “used to” or “would” are often used. English often uses these forms to contrast the past with the present.

See also:

Present simple **1** Past simple **4**

Past continuous **10** Adverbs of frequency **102**

15.1 “USED TO”

“Used to” can be used with the base form of a verb to talk about past habits.

Refers to a past habit.
We used to play tennis every day, but now we prefer golf.



“Used to” can also be used to talk about fixed states at some indefinite time in the past.

Refers to a past state.
We used to live in London before we moved to Sydney.



FURTHER EXAMPLES

Did you use to ride a scooter when you were a student?



I used to eat lunch on my own, but now I sit with friends.



I used to eat meat, but now I'm a vegetarian.



“Used” becomes “use” in questions and negative forms.
I didn't use to believe in ghosts until I visited a haunted house.



We didn't use to think England was cold until we moved here.



I didn't use to be afraid of spiders until I visited Australia.

